RADIANT 2026

History

Medieval India :-

The Cholas

Lecture - 01

By - Joginder Singh Chahar Sir



Topics

to be covered

1. Sources



Syllabus

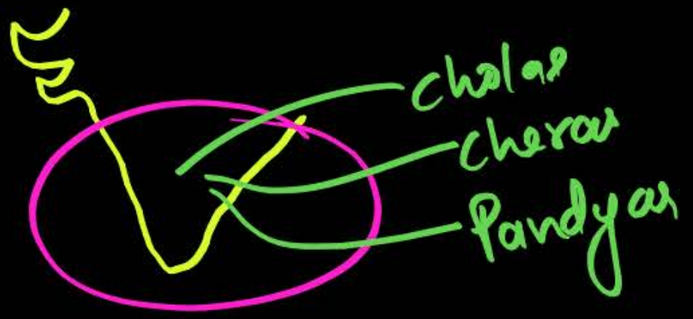
7. Medieval India

(a) The Cholas

Sources: Inscriptions; Brihadishwara Temple. Political history and administration (Rajaraja I, Rajendra I).

Cholas

Southern Rulers

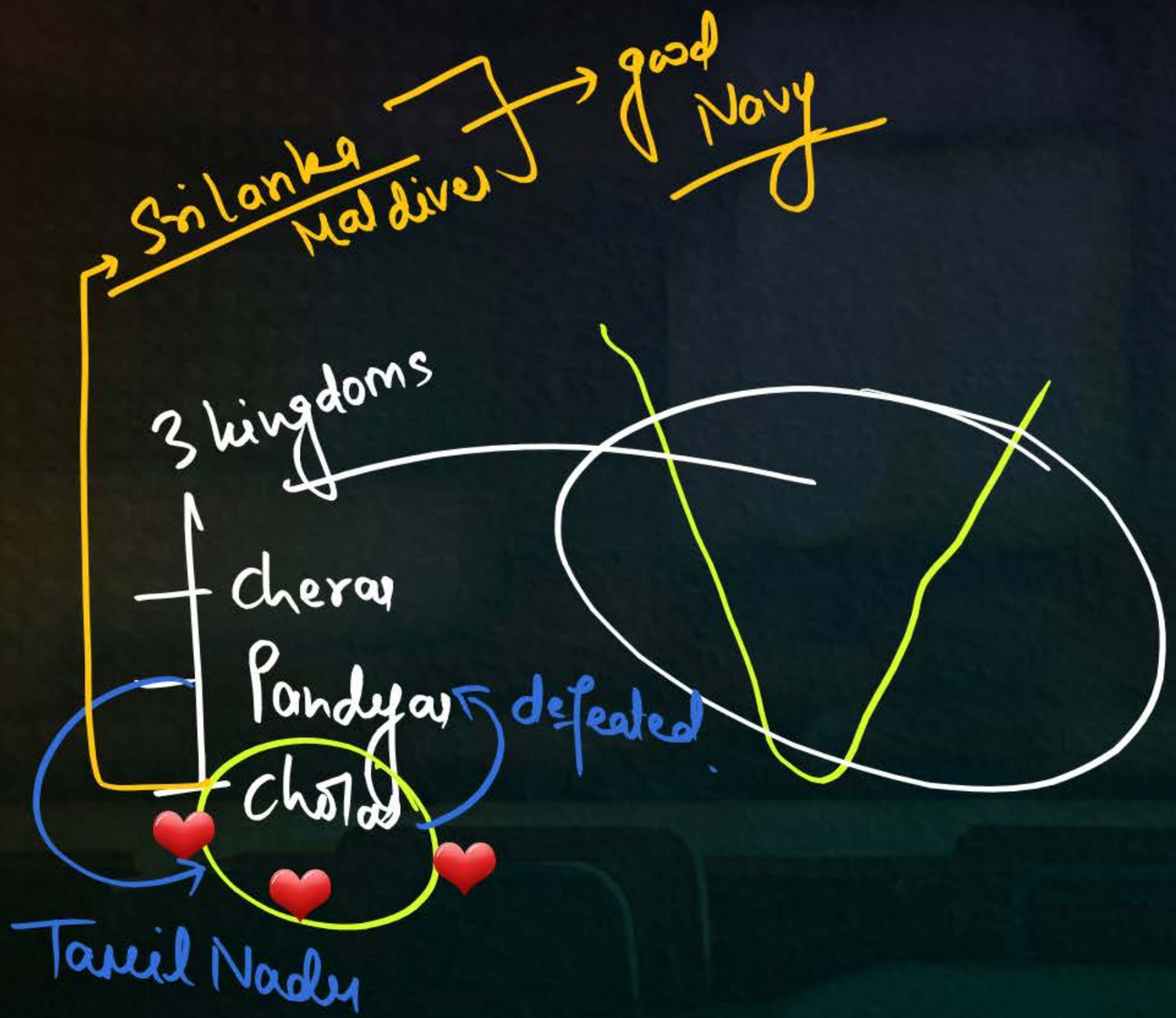


The southern part of the Indian peninsula was home to three powerful kingdoms the Cheras, the Pandyas and the Cholas.

The most powerful of the three were the Cholas.

The Chola Empire developed a powerful navy which enabled them to develop India's sea-trade in the Indian Ocean and to conquer Sri Lanka and the Maldives Islands.

By the end of the 9th century, **the Cholas defeated the Pallavas of Kanchi and weakened the Pandyas bringing the Tamil country** (Tondamandala) under their control.


Sri Lanka
Maldives
good Navy
3 kingdoms
Cheras
Pandyas
defeated
Cholas
Tamil Nadu



Sources: Inscriptions

written things: copper plate, stones, pillars etc

The main source of information for the history of the Chola period is the large number of inscriptions of that period.

Rajaraja I conceived the idea of prefixing to his inscriptions the main achievements of his reign.

Ruling period

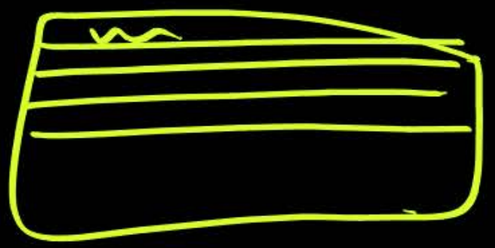
The example of Rajaraja was followed by his successors as well.

Consequently, **there exists a formal record of the transactions made by each Chola ruler.**

The **inscriptions of the Cholas are in the form of Copper-plate grants, stone inscriptions and inscriptions made on the walls and pillars of temples.**

The Copper-plate grants known as Anbil and Karandi and the Kanyakumari stone inscription give a long list of rulers indicating the origin of the Chola dynasty.

Another set of Copper- plate contains 31 copper sheets.



These plates are written in Sanskrit and Tamil.

They record a grant made to a temple by Rajendra Chola I.

The inscriptions provide the following information about the Cholas.

(i) They tell us about the Chola administration. For example, the Uttaramerur inscription gives information on the village administration, taxation and land revenue.

(ii) They record gifts and endowments to temples and brahmanas. Copper-plate inscriptions are the records of grants of villages, plots of land or other privileges to individuals or institutions by the Cholas. For example, the Leyden grant (so called as they are preserved in the Museum of Leyden in Holland) of Parantaka Chola and those of Parakesari Uttama Chola are among the most important.

(iii) They inform us about the construction of a temple or the setting up of a new image of the deity. — god/goddesses

(iv) Some inscriptions have royal orders on taxation and land revenue, resolutions of village assemblies, judgements delivered against persons guilty of theft, murder and other crimes.

The Brihadeshwara temple

The Cholas built a number of temples.

The gateway of the temple was called 'gopuram'.

The main shrine was known as the 'garbhagriha'.

Here, the images of gods and goddesses were kept.

These images were made either of stone or bronze.

The 'mandapa' or the audience hall, was a place where people gathered for prayers.



It was built in front of the main shrine.

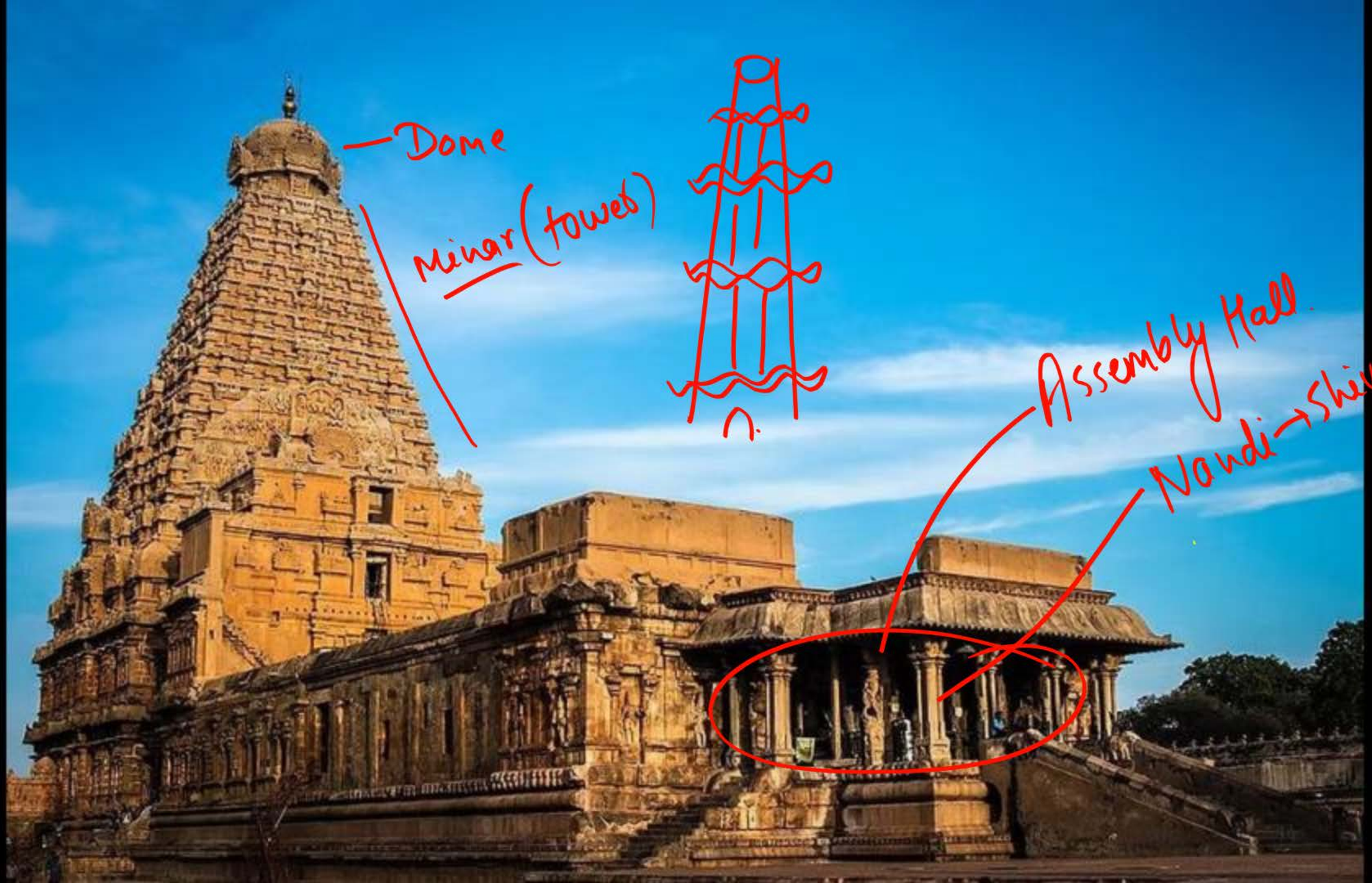


The chief features of Chola temples are their massive vimanas or towers and spacious courtyards.

The best example of Chola temple is the Brihadeshwara, also known as Rajarajeshwara temple, dedicated to Lord Shiva.

It is located at Thanjavur and was built by the Chola king, Rajaraja I.

It is one of the best specimens of Dravidian style of architecture.

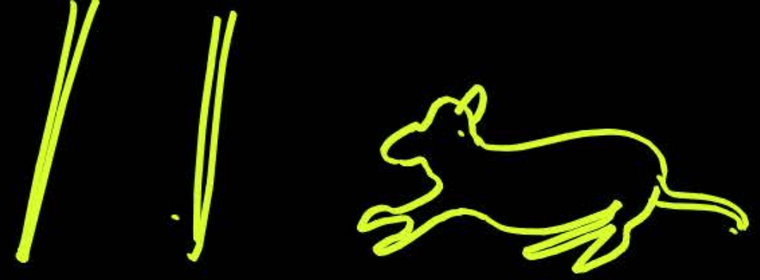

Dome
Minar (towers)
Assembly Hall
Nandi → Shiv.

The main structure of the temple has a great vimana or tower which rises to a height of 66 metres.

It is crowned by a massive dome consisting of a single block of stone, 7.6 metres high and weighing about 80 tons.

The main temple is built of 130,000 tons of granite.

The massive temple building is covered from the base to the top with sculptures and decorative mouldings.



The shrine houses a gigantic Shiva Lingam, cut in a monolithic rock about 8.87 metres high.

The temple has many structures such as a Nandi Pavilion, a pillared portico and a large assembly hall.

The temple has been declared as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO.





The Brihadeshwara temple provides the following information:

(i) The temple has a portrait of Rajaraja Chola paying obeisance to Lord Nataraja.

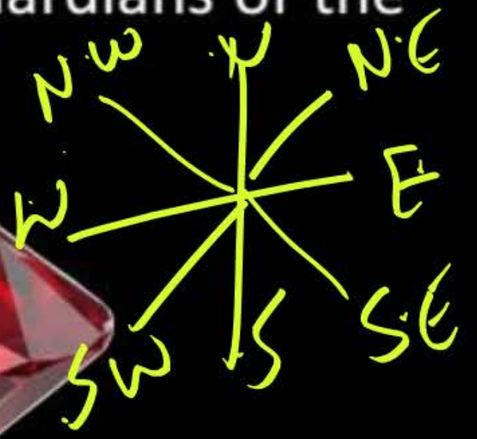
(ii) Inscriptions in the temple point towards Rajaraja as the chief architect of the temple.

(iii) Depictions of dancers showing one hundred eight karanas (synchronised movements of hands and feet) in Bharata Natyam are carved here. It shows that the temple was a platform for talented dancers to showcase their talent. These depictions are first of their kind.

(iv) The inscriptions mention the different kinds of jewels used in the Chola period. A total of twenty three different types of pearls, eleven varieties of diamonds and rubies are mentioned in these inscriptions.

(v) It is one of the few temples that have Ashta-Dikpaalakas (Guardians of the eight directions) idols.





Question

#Q. Inscriptions of the Cholas are in which forms?

A Stone inscriptions

B Copper-plate grants

C Inscriptions on temple pillars

D All of the above.

Question

#Q. What are the chief features of Chola temples?

A Audience halls

B Large vimanas and courtyards

C Images of deities

D All of the above. ✓

Question

#Q. The main shrine in the Brihadeshwara Temple was called:

A Gopuram

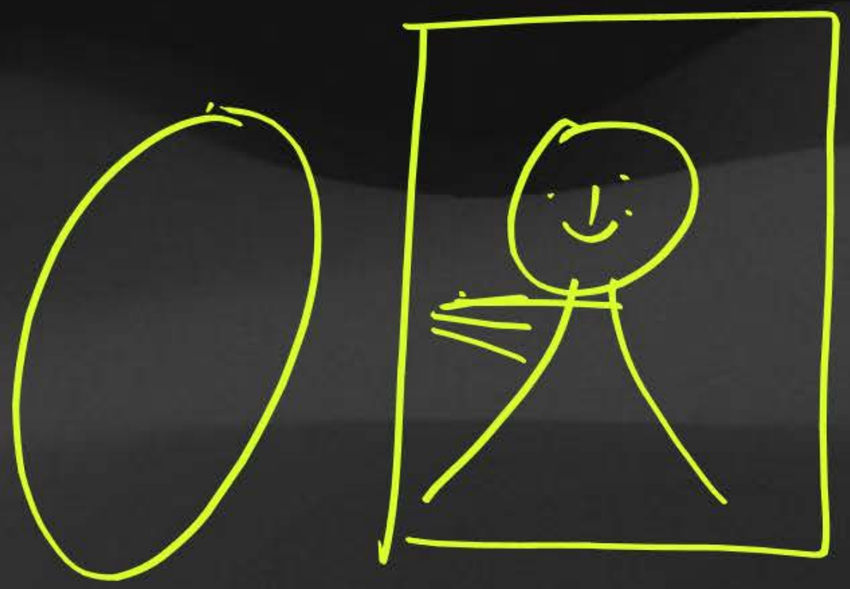
B Garbhagriha

C Lingam

D Mandapa

Question

#Q. The temple has a portrait of Rajaraja Chola paying obeisance to Lord_____.



A Vishnu

B Shiva

C Nataraja ✓

D None of these


Bye
Bye
Thank you